

FIRST CHINA TRIP KIT

China Payment & Apps Setup Guide

A practical pre-arrival setup guide for Alipay, WeChat Pay, essential apps, and first-day payment backups.

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Use this guide for	Keep as backup
Preparing payment apps, essential apps, internet access, hotel address cards, and first-day tests before arrival.	Save the PDF offline and print the cards you may need for taxis, hotels, and checkout counters.

Important disclaimer

Travel planning information only

This guide provides travel planning information only. It is not legal, immigration, financial, banking, or official government advice. Payment app support, card acceptance, verification rules, transport policies, and travel requirements may change. Always verify current official information before traveling.

Do not use this guide as	Use this guide as
A guarantee that an app, bank card, visa, route, or merchant payment will work.	A practical pre-trip checklist and backup planning tool.
A replacement for official app notices, bank card rules, immigration rules, or transport policies.	A way to organize what to verify before booking and before relying on payment apps.

Quick setup overview

☐	Install Alipay.
☐	Add international card if supported.
☐	Install WeChat.
☐	Prepare translation app.
☐	Prepare map app.
☐	Prepare eSIM / roaming.
☐	Save hotel address in Chinese.
☐	Carry backup cash.
☐	Carry physical bank card.
☐	Test payment on arrival day.

Best order

Set up apps before you fly, save hotel details offline, then make one small purchase after arrival before depending on mobile payment for taxis or dinner.

Alipay setup checklist

Section	What to prepare	Backup plan
Passport	Use the same passport name format if identity details are requested.	Keep passport available during setup and hotel check-in.
International card	Add a card if supported by your account and card issuer.	Prepare another card, cash, and a physical card.
Phone number	Use a number you can access while traveling.	Keep your home SIM available if bank SMS is needed.
Bank app	Make sure your bank app and security prompts work overseas.	Notify your bank of travel if your issuer recommends it.
Stable internet	Use reliable Wi-Fi or mobile data during setup.	Do urgent purchases with a working backup first.
First-day payment test	Test with water or a small snack.	Do not make taxis or dinner your first test.
Common setup issues	Card declined, SMS not received, identity prompt, app language confusion.	Step aside, screenshot the prompt, and ask hotel staff if needed.

Careful wording

Alipay may work well for many foreign visitors, but support can depend on account status, card issuer, verification, app rules, and merchant flows. Prepare a backup.

WeChat / WeChat Pay setup checklist

Topic	Use	Planning note
Why WeChat is useful	Messaging, local contact, restaurant ordering, mini programs, and some payment flows.	Install before arrival and confirm you can sign in.
Messaging use	Hotels, drivers, contacts, and service providers may use WeChat.	Keep account access stable before you travel.
Payment backup	WeChat Pay can be useful when a merchant or mini program expects it.	Treat it as a backup until you have tested it.
Mini programs	Restaurants, attractions, ride-hailing, and services may use mini programs.	Some flows can be hard without Chinese support.
Setup friction warning	Foreign card support and verification can vary.	Do not make WeChat Pay your only payment option.
If WeChat Pay does not work	Use Alipay, cash, physical card, or hotel help.	Solve account issues later away from the queue.
When to use Alipay first	Everyday QR payments and simple first-day purchases.	Test both options before relying on either.

Payment backup decision tree

If this happens	Try this	Then this	Final backup
Alipay works	Use it as your primary payment method.	Still keep a backup card and cash.	Save successful setup notes.
Alipay card fails	Try another card.	Check bank app or issuer security prompt.	Use cash, physical card, or hotel help.
WeChat Pay works	Use it as a backup.	Use where restaurants or mini programs expect it.	Do not remove other backups.
App payment fails	Reconnect data and retry once.	Try another wallet or cashier scan flow.	Use cash / physical card / hotel help.
Taxi payment fails	Ask driver if cash is possible.	Call hotel or show hotel phone number.	Ask hotel to help resolve the fare.
No internet	Use offline hotel address and saved screenshots.	Use cash and physical card.	Get hotel or station staff help.

Rule of thumb

Pay with a working backup first. Debug account or bank issues later, away from a taxi, restaurant line, or checkout counter.

Essential China app stack

App / Tool	Chinese name	Main use	Install before arrival?	Foreigner friction	Backup tip
Alipay	支付宝	Payment, QR codes, ride-hailing, some services.	Yes	Medium	Carry card and cash.
WeChat	微信	Messaging, payment backup, mini programs.	Yes	Medium / High	Use Alipay first if needed.
Translation app	-	Text, voice, camera translation.	Yes	Low	Download offline Chinese.
Map app	-	Routes, addresses, transit.	Yes	Medium	Save screenshots.
eSIM / roaming app	-	Mobile data setup and support.	Yes	Medium	Keep hotel Wi-Fi plan.
Trip.com or train booking support	-	Train and hotel booking help.	Yes	Low / Medium	Save passport-linked tickets.
DiDi	滴滴	Ride-hailing.	Optional	Medium	Hotel can help call taxi.
Amap	高德地图	Local maps and transit.	Optional	High	Use screenshots or translation.
12306	中国铁路12306	Official train tickets.	Optional	High	Use booking platform or station help.
Offline screenshot folder	-	Backup for addresses and tickets.	Yes	Low	Keep it available without data.

First-day payment test

☐	Go to a convenience store.
☐	Buy water or a small snack.
☐	Test Alipay.
☐	Confirm card charge.
☐	Save receipt if needed.
☐	Keep cash ready.
☐	Do not depend on taxis or dinner before testing payment.

Good test	Avoid as first test
A small purchase near your hotel, airport, or station.	Taxi fare, group dinner, attraction entry, or any queue where people are waiting behind you.
A staffed counter where you can step aside if needed.	A rushed self-service kiosk with weak mobile data.

Troubleshooting table

Problem	Possible reason	What to try	Backup
Card cannot be added	Issuer support, identity prompt, app rule, network issue.	Try another card, stable Wi-Fi, or bank app check.	Cash, physical card, hotel help.
SMS verification does not arrive	Roaming, SIM, spam filter, delay.	Wait, reconnect, check home SIM access.	Use another payment path.
Merchant says payment failed	QR flow, network, issuer block, merchant setting.	Try again once, lower amount, or another wallet.	Cash or physical card.
App asks for identity verification	Account rules or transaction risk check.	Read prompt carefully; avoid sharing sensitive data with strangers.	Use backup payment.
No internet after landing	Roaming/eSIM not active or airport coverage issue.	Use airport/hotel Wi-Fi and activation notes.	Cash, screenshots, hotel address.
Taxi cannot accept card	Taxi expects cash or QR payment.	Ask about cash before ride if possible.	Hotel call or ride-hailing app.
Restaurant only accepts QR payment	Ordering/payment inside QR or mini program.	Ask staff to help or order at cashier.	Choose simpler first meal.
Bank blocks transaction	Issuer fraud check or travel rule.	Open bank app or call support later.	Backup card or cash.

Useful Chinese payment phrases

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Can I pay with Alipay?	我可以用支付宝支付吗？	Wǒ kěyǐ yòng Zhīfùbǎo zhīfù ma?
Can I pay with WeChat Pay?	可以用微信支付吗？	Kěyǐ yòng Wēixìn zhīfù ma?
Can I pay by card?	可以刷卡吗？	Kěyǐ shuākǎ ma?
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Kěyǐ yòng xiànjīn ma?
The payment failed.	支付失败了。	Zhīfù shībài le.
Could you scan my QR code?	您可以扫我的付款码吗？	Nín kěyǐ sǎo wǒ de fùkuǎn mǎ ma?

How to use this page

Show the Chinese characters on your phone. Keep the page available offline in case translation apps or mobile data are not working.

Taxi and hotel phrase card

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Please help me call a taxi.	请帮我叫一辆出租车。	Qǐng bāng wǒ jiào yí liàng chūzūchē.
This is my hotel address.	这是我的酒店地址。	Zhè shì wǒ de jiǔdiàn dìzhǐ.
Please take me to this address.	请带我去这个地址。	Qǐng dài wǒ qù zhège dìzhǐ.
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Kěyǐ yòng xiànjīn ma?

Taxi note

If your destination is difficult to explain, show the Chinese address and hotel phone number. Hotel staff can often help confirm the destination before you leave.

Hotel address card template

Field	Write your details here
Hotel English name	
Hotel Chinese name	
Chinese address	
Hotel phone	
Nearest metro station	
Emergency contact	
Notes	

Offline tip

Save this card as a screenshot and print one copy. It is useful for taxis, station help desks, and hotel check-in issues.

Payment backup card

Backup item	Write your plan here
Primary payment	
Backup payment	
Cash location	
Bank support number	
Hotel phone	
Phrase	可以用现金吗？ / Kěyǐ yòng xiànjīn ma? / Can I pay with cash?

Do not store sensitive data

Do not write full card numbers, account passwords, or bank login details on this card. Keep it practical and non-sensitive.

Before you fly checklist

Area	Ready check
Payment	Alipay installed; WeChat installed; card prepared; cash backup ready.
Apps	Translation, maps, ride-hailing, train support, and screenshot folder ready.
Internet	Roaming, eSIM, SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi plan confirmed.
Hotel address	Chinese name, address, phone, and nearest metro saved offline.
Train tickets	Passport-linked details and station names saved.
Passport	Passport accessible for hotel, trains, and tickets.
Cash	Small RMB backup carried safely.
Power bank	Charged and packed for payment and maps.
Emergency phrases	Payment, taxi, hotel, and cash phrases saved offline.

Official resources to verify

Resource	What to verify
Alipay official resources	Current foreign card support, identity requirements, fees, and payment limits.
WeChat Pay official resources	Current foreign card support, wallet availability, verification, and usage limits.
China government payment guidance for overseas visitors	Current official visitor payment guidance and accepted methods.
Your own bank card issuer	Travel rules, fraud checks, overseas fees, SMS prompts, and card restrictions.
Hotel or travel provider	Address, payment options, deposit rules, local taxi or arrival help.

Verify before booking

Payment support, card acceptance, transport policies, and travel requirements may change. Check official resources before relying on any single setup.

Need more China trip help?

Next steps

Visit www.firstchinatripkit.com for city kits, itinerary kits, travel essentials, and free planning tools.

Resource	Where to go
City kits	Choose your first China base and save useful Chinese addresses.
Itinerary kits	Build routes that leave room for jet lag, transfers, and weather.
Travel essentials	Prepare visa, internet, train, food, safety, and basic Chinese notes.
Free tools	Use checklists, route pickers, and planning helpers.
Support	hello@firstchinatripkit.com

Thank you

Thanks for supporting First China Trip Kit. The guide stays practical, cautious, and focused on first-time visitors.